

Zak the KNIFE

KHAN

| By Sharda Ugra |

As the men in blue begin their tough campaign in New Zealand, they have at the helm of their attack a man at the peak of his powers and on the verge of becoming only the third Indian fast bowler to claim 200 Test wickets

July 20, 2007, 6 a.m., London. Dawn on the second day of the Lord's Test and Zaheer Khan was awake. Even though he had long abandoned the 15-minute scram-

ble between bed and bus without getting fined, it was still too darn early. Day one had produced none for 55 off 14 %\$#@ overs. It wasn't supposed to be like this.

In 2006, he had cleaned up 78 wickets as Worcestershire's overseas pro. He was supposed to lead the Indian attack in England, expected to do better than this bloody awful none for 55 on Day One. What must the rest be thinking? There goes Zak again, missing his moment?

He called a friend in India. "Speak to me," he said, and they did. Just regular things, as he listened and laughed, his insides unknotted themselves, his mind cleared, his anxiety drained away. He downed his habitual pot of morning coffee and watched the day arrive outside his window. As he slowly got ready, he knew it was all going to be fine. He just knew.

From that day to this, in 18 months Zaheer, 30, has taken 86 wickets (49 in Tests), won two Man of the Series awards, banished some baggy green ghouls, strengthened his body and lightened his soul. These days he waits at the top of his run, breathing the clean, crisp air of New Zealand. He is three wickets short of becoming only third Indian paceman after Kapil Dev and Javagal Srinath to claim 200 Test wickets but has done more than stack up the numbers.

Zaheer has re-written the narrative of his own unpredictable story, re-defined the course of his career and has emerged, finally, as the bowler India have waited for him to be. He has gone from edgy, brittle paceman to the leader of India's attack, the man who has delivered some of its most emphatic victories in the last two seasons. From an uncertain performer always on the fringe of hitting his stride to a mature bowler the Indians now rely on. He forms one half of what some call the best new ball-pair in the world, whose presence gives the Indian bowling attack its heft and will make all opposition think twice about loading their decks in bowlers' favour.

As all the talk revolves around fiendish Kiwi pitch and weather conditions and whose labour it would be to bowl into the wind, Zaheer says, "All I need is swing—it doesn't matter which way it goes, reverse, conventional, inswing, outswing. If outswing is working on one day, I'll go with outswing, if it's inswing then fine... The bottom line is that I should be in good rhythm, I should be in a good zone and the ball should swing." He talks about rhythm and swing like a jazz musician but the instrument he is referring to here is his body.